

United States of America



Area 3,716,654 sq miles
(9,626,091 sq km)
Population 313 million
Capital Washington, D.C.
Currency US dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 78 years



The United States of America (USA) was founded in 1776 on principles of individual freedom and a government voted for by the people. It is now the most powerful country in the world and the third most populated. The main landmass is made up of 48 of the country's 50 states. The other two are

Alaska, on the northwest tip of the North American continent, and Hawaii, an island chain in the Pacific Ocean. The country's Hispanic community makes up 13 percent of the population, and is growing rapidly. The first African-American president, Barack Obama, was elected in 2008.

▲ **MANHATTAN SKYLINE**
Manhattan, the smallest but most densely populated of New York City's five boroughs, is an island at the mouth of the Hudson River.

Canada



Area 3,855,103 sq miles
(9,984,670 sq km)
Population 34.3 million
Capital Ottawa
Currency Canadian dollar
Official languages English and French
Life expectancy 80 years



Canada is the world's second-largest country in terms of land area. It spans six time zones, from Newfoundland in the east to British Columbia in the west. To its north lies the Arctic Ocean. Most Canadians are descendants of immigrants from Britain, France, Ireland, and other European

countries. Canada also has an indigenous population of about one million people, who are known as the First Nations. Canada is ranked by the United Nations (UN) as one of the best countries to live in, with the cities of Vancouver, Toronto, and Calgary featuring in the world's top ten cities according to living conditions.

► **BROWN BEAR**
One of the largest land animals, the brown bear lives in the mountainous regions of Canada. Activities such as logging have affected its habitat and reduced its numbers.



Guatemala



Area 42,043 sq miles
(108,890 sq km)
Population 14.8 million
Capital Guatemala City
Currency Quetzal
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 70 years



Once home to the ancient Mayan civilization, Guatemala is mostly made up of highlands. More than half of Guatemalans are descendants of the original Mayas, who mostly live in the highlands as farmers. Agriculture contributes to nearly a quarter of Guatemala's export earnings.

Belize



Area 8,867 sq miles
(22,966 sq km)
Population 300,000
Capital Belmopan
Currency Belizean dollar
Official language English
Life expectancy 72 years



Formerly known as British Honduras, Belize was the last Central American country to gain independence, in 1981. On its east coast, in the waters of the Caribbean Sea, lies the world's second largest coral reef system. Belize has the lowest population of Central America, and almost half of its land area is still covered in forests.

El Salvador



Area 8,124 sq miles
(21,040 sq km)
Population 6.2 million
Capital San Salvador
Currency Salvadorean colón
Official language Spanish
Life expectancy 72 years



Located on the Pacific coast, El Salvador is the smallest and most densely populated nation in Central America. Within its borders lie the boundaries of three tectonic plates, which means there are frequent earthquakes and volcanic eruptions. The volcanic activity provides a source of relatively cheap geothermal energy.

